Dvar Torah: Parshas Vayakhel-Pekudei

The Testimony of Creation: Building From the Foundation

A Personal Beginning

This week we conclude Sefer Shemos with the double parsha of Vayakhel-Pekudei. On a personal note, this Shabbos marks the tenth yahrtzeit of my grandmother, Tzila bas Avraham Chaim, zichronah livrachah. She is deeply missed. Ten years. The number ten, yud, represents shleimus, completion, wholeness. It's a godly number. My grandmother was truly a godly woman, and in her memory, the ideas we'll explore today feel especially meaningful.

We're also approaching Pesach, just a few weeks away. This is the time when we begin preparing, learning the halachos of Pesach, connecting to the themes of redemption. And as we'll see, there's a powerful thread running through this week's parsha that ties together Shabbos, the Mishkan, and the upcoming Seder in ways that speak directly to how we live as Jews in this world.

From Plans to Action

Parshas Vayakhel opens with Moshe Rabbeinu gathering all of Klal Yisrael together. "וַיַּקְהֵל מֹשֶׁה" (Shemos 35:1) - "Vayakhel Moshe," Moshe assembled. Everyone was there. Those who were more observant, those who were less observant, those who were completely distant. All brought together for what comes next.

And what does Moshe say first? Before diving into the construction of the Mishkan, before assigning roles and responsibilities, he gives over just a few lines about Hilchos Shabbos. Including one of the most well-known melachos: "לֹא תְבַעֲרוּ אֵשׁ בְּכֹל מֹשְׁבֹתֵיכֶם בְּיוֹם הַשַּׁבָּת" (Shemos 35:3), do not light a fire in any of your dwellings on the day of Shabbos.

Then, immediately afterward, the Torah transitions into the detailed construction of the Mishkan and all its vessels.

This creates an interesting contrast. In the previous parshiyos, Terumah and Tetzaveh, the Torah described the Mishkan in terms of instructions. Those sections explained how the Mishkan should be built. They were the blueprints, the divine architectural plans.

But in Vayakhel-Pekudei, we move from theory to practice. The plans have been given. Now the people begin the actual work. Yet before the hammers fall, before the gold is shaped, before the construction begins, the Torah pauses to remind us about Shabbos.

Why?

Shabbos as Testimony

Within the halachos of Shabbos, we find the famous dual expression: "שָׁמוֹר" and "זָכוֹר" (Shemos 20:8, Devarim 5:12) - Shamor v'Zachor, guard and remember. But Shabbos is more than a set of restrictions or ritual obligations. Shabbos is described in the Torah as an "אוֹת" (Shemos 31:13), a sign, and as "עֵדוּת", testimony.

Every time we keep Shabbos, we bear witness to the fundamental truth that Hashem created the world in six days and rested on the seventh. "כִּי שֵׁשֶׁת יָמִים עָשָׂה ה' אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ וּבַיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי שָׁבַת וַיִּנָּפַשׁ" (Shemos 31:17). In six days Hashem made heaven and earth, and on the seventh day He rested and was refreshed.

Shabbos was given to us as a gift. But part of receiving that gift is our responsibility to testify to Hashem's creation of the world. In other words, Shabbos is not only about rest. Shabbos is about belief. Shabbos is about declaring, through our actions and our abstention from creative work, that there is a Creator and we are not Him.

This is the foundation. This is where everything begins.

We Are the Mishkan

This idea leads to a deeper question. What exactly is the Mishkan? The Mishkan was not only a physical structure made of gold and silver, acacia wood and fine linen. At its deepest level, the Mishkan represents something far greater.

We've spoken about this in previous weeks: "וְעָשׂוּ לִי מִקְדָּשׁ וְשָׁכַנְתִּי בְּתוֹכָם" (Shemos 25:8). Make for Me a sanctuary and I will dwell "b'tocham," in them, not in it. The Jewish people themselves are meant to be the dwelling place for Hashem in this world.

But that can only begin with one fundamental belief: that Hashem created the world and that this world exists for His presence within it.

Before we can build the external Mishkan, we must establish the internal foundation. Before we can become a dwelling place for the Shechinah, we must first testify to the most basic truth: Hashem is the Creator.

That's why Moshe first gathers all Jews, of all levels of observance, to begin with Shabbos. Before all the detailed construction, before the intricate craftsmanship, before the gold and the jewels and the artistry, he reminds everyone: Don't light a fire on Shabbos. Remember who created the world.

Two Opposite Worldviews

This brings us to a powerful contrast within halacha. Two mitzvos, or more accurately, two spiritual realities, stand in direct opposition to one another: Shabbos and Avodah Zarah.

Shabbos declares that Hashem created the world. Avodah Zarah denies that reality. Someone who worships idols is essentially rejecting the belief that Hashem created and controls the world. They're attributing creative power to something other than the one Creator.

In that sense, Shabbos and Avodah Zarah express two completely opposite worldviews. Shabbos says: There is one God who made everything. Avodah Zarah says: Power is divided, fragmented, available through other channels.

The halachic literature treats these two concepts as deeply interconnected. Violating Shabbos in certain ways is considered akin to denying Hashem's creation. Engaging in Avodah Zarah is the ultimate rejection of that same truth.

But here's where it gets interesting, and where we begin to connect to Pesach.

The Four Cups and a Halachic Question

Pesach is truly the chag of the Jewish people. It commemorates the moment when Hashem took us out of Mitzrayim and formed us into a nation dedicated to Him. At the center of the Pesach Seder are the Arba Kosos, the four cups of wine, representing the four expressions of redemption: "וְהוֹצֵאתִי... וְהִצַּלְתִּי... וְגָאַלְתִּי... וְלָקַחְתִּי" (Shemos 6:6-7) - "V'hotzeisi, v'hitzalti, v'ga'alti, v'lakachti."

But the use of wine at the Seder leads to a practical halachic situation that many families encounter. Sometimes family members or friends who are not fully observant join the Seder. Sometimes people are involved in kiruv, in outreach, and host guests who are Jewish but not necessarily living fully observant lives.

This raises a common halachic question: What about the wine? Specifically, the difference between mevushal (cooked) and non-mevushal wine, and the broader halachos of yayin nesech, wine that becomes prohibited under certain conditions.

The topic is complex, with many details and distinctions. But in simplified terms, the question becomes: If a Jew who is not fully observant handles wine, does that wine become prohibited?

The Halachic Discussion

Within the halachic literature, we find multiple discussions of this issue. One appears in Shulchan Aruch Yoreh Deah 119, dealing with someone who is "chashud," someone whose reliability in halacha is questionable. Another discussion appears in Yoreh Deah 124, which deals specifically with the halachos of yayin nesech.

For example, one halacha discusses a case where a person lives among non-Jews and even participates with them in Avodah Zarah, yet when he comes into a Jewish environment, he identifies himself as a Jew. In that case, the halacha states that his contact with wine does not automatically render the wine yayin nesech.

On the other hand, another halacha states that someone who is known to be a mumar, someone known to engage in Avodah Zarah, can render wine prohibited through contact. Yet even in that situation, if the person says that he has done teshuvah, the halacha tells us: We believe him.

This creates a real tension within the halachic discussion. These are not simple, black-and-white situations. There is significant discussion among the poskim about how these halachos should be understood and applied.

The Question of the Heart

Ultimately, many of the earlier and later commentators ask a deeper question: What is actually happening in that person's heart? What is their internal reality?

There are poskim who explain that sometimes a Jew who does not keep Shabbos, or who appears to be distant from observance, may still internally believe in Hashem. For example, there are discussions about a Jew who makes Kiddush on Friday night and then two minutes later goes out, drives, and performs melachos of Shabbos.

It sounds contradictory. It is contradictory. But many poskim say that such a person may still not render wine yayin nesech. Why? Because in their heart, in their internal reality, and even in some of their actions, they still recognize that Hashem created the world.

They know that Hashem created the world. They just don't know how to experience that fully. They don't know how to become the Mishkan that we've been describing. They don't know how to take those thoughts and transform them into consistent action.

But they know the reality. They know the truth on some level.

A Huge Yeshuah

This is a huge yeshuah, a tremendous source of hope, as we approach Pesach. Because if the Torah was given to the Jewish people, and if every Jew is meant to be the Mishkan, meant to be the bayis, the house and the home for Hashem in this world, then we can also say that other Jews know this as well.

They know it. They mean it. They believe it in their hearts. They may simply not know how to do it yet. They may not have the tools. They may not have been taught. They may be struggling with their own internal conflicts.

But the foundation is there. The belief exists.

This is what Moshe Rabbeinu was saying when he gathered everyone together. Not just the tzaddikim. Not just the learned or the pious. Everyone. Because everyone has this foundation within them. Everyone has the capacity to testify to Hashem's creation.

The Role Models We Need

When we look at the role models that the Torah gives us, and this parsha focuses strongly on role models, we need to think carefully about who those role models are.

Think about Aharon HaKohen. Aharon was involved in the events surrounding the Eigel HaZahav. The gold was brought to him. It was melted under his watch. And yet, Aharon is also described as someone who "אוֹהֵב שָׁלוֹם וְרוֹדֵף שָׁלוֹם אוֹהֵב אֶת הַבְּרִיּוֹת וּמְקָרְבָן לַתּוֹרָה" (Pirkei Avos 1:12), loved peace and pursued peace, loved people and brought them close to Torah.

Aharon increased ahavas Yisrael among the people. He would sometimes even alter words slightly in order to create peace between people and strengthen shalom bayis. He saw the good in everyone. He believed that every Jew, at their core, wanted to do what was right.

That's the kind of role model the Torah is presenting. Not someone who draws lines and creates divisions. Not someone who looks for ways to separate and exclude. But someone who gathers people together, who finds the common foundation, who believes in the essential goodness and belief within every Jewish heart.

Starting With the Simplest Thing

And this brings us back to where Moshe begins in this week's parsha. Before entering into the detailed construction of the Mishkan, before assigning the intricate tasks, Moshe starts with the prohibition of lighting a fire on Shabbos.

If you ask even a non-observant Jew, "What's one thing you're not supposed to do on Shabbos?" many of them will answer: "You don't light a fire." They know this. It's one of the most basic, widely known halachos.

But the deeper message is not just the technical rule. The deeper message is the principle behind it: Hashem created the world in six days and rested on the seventh. That is the foundation of our belief. Hashem created the world. Hashem created us. And Hashem created within us the ability to love, appreciate, and care for one another.

Fire is a fascinating symbol. Fire can represent passion, intensity, heat, and destruction. But fire can also represent love. There is a kosher way to channel passion and love, and there is a destructive way to use them. Love of Hashem and love of other Jews becomes the foundation for everything else. When that love burns properly, it illuminates. When it burns improperly, it destroys.

Aharon understood this deeply. He knew how to channel the fire of passion into love, into peace, into bringing people closer to each other and closer to Hashem. And Moshe, by beginning with this simple prohibition, is teaching us the same lesson.

That's where Moshe begins. Not with the complicated blueprints. Not with the intricate details of the Mishkan's construction. He begins with the most basic, unifying idea: Remember Shabbos. Remember that Hashem created the world.

Building From the Foundation

Only after that foundation is established can we move into the detailed work of building the Mishkan. And the Torah repeats again and again who was responsible for each task, each part of the construction. "בְּצַלְאֵל בֶּן אוּרִי בֶן חוּר" (Shemos 35:30), Betzalel son of Uri son of Chur, was filled with wisdom and understanding. "אָהֳלִיאָב בֶּן אֲחִיסָמָךְ" (Shemos 35:34), Oholiav son of Achisamach, was given the ability to teach.

Different people had different roles. Different people had different responsibilities. Not everyone needed to perform the same job. Some worked with gold, some with silver, some with wood, some with fabric. Some were craftsmen, some were teachers, some were organizers.

But everyone began with the same foundation: Hashem created the world, and we are here to be a dwelling place for Him.

The Message for Our Time

There are many details that people forget because they become focused only on the fine points and the technical debates. People sometimes look for ways to divide. They ask: How can I separate from someone else? How can I draw a line between myself and others? Who's in and who's out?

But Moshe Rabbeinu, in this double parsha, as we conclude Sefer Shemos, reminds us of something crucial before we enter into all the fine details. He reminds us to start with love. To start with unity. To start with the recognition that every Jew, at their core, knows the truth.

They know that Hashem created the world. They may not know how to live that truth fully yet. But the knowledge is there. The foundation exists.

Our job is not to exclude them. Our job is to teach them, to love them, to show them how to build on that foundation. Just as Moshe gathered everyone together, just as Aharon pursued peace and increased love, we too are meant to bring people closer, not push them away.

Questions for Your Shabbos Table

As we conclude Sefer Shemos and prepare for Pesach, consider these reflections:

On Foundation:

- What is the most basic belief that grounds my Jewish identity?
- Do I remember to build from that foundation, or do I get lost in details?

On Seeing Others:

- When I encounter Jews who are less observant, do I look for the foundation of belief within them?
- Am I channeling my passion and fire toward love and unity, or toward division?

On Pesach:

- As I prepare for the Seder, how can I create an environment where every Jew feels welcomed and valued?
- What message of redemption and belonging do I want to share at my table?

Closing: From Sefer Shemos to Pesach

We close Sefer Shemos this week. We've journeyed from slavery to redemption, from Mitzrayim to Sinai, from receiving the Torah to building the Mishkan. And the final message, as we prepare to enter Sefer Vayikra, is this: Start simple. Start with the foundation. Don't light the fire improperly. Remember that Hashem created the world.

And from there, we can begin to build everything else. The Mishkan in the desert. The Mishkan within ourselves. The dwelling place for Hashem in this world.

As we approach Pesach, the chag of redemption, let us remember that redemption begins with recognizing the spark of belief in every Jewish heart. Even those who seem distant, even those who struggle, even those who don't yet know how to live the truth they carry within them.

They know. We know. Hashem created the world. Hashem created us. And Hashem gave us the ability to love one another, to build together, to become a dwelling place for His presence.

May we merit to see the rebuilding of the Beis HaMikdash speedily in our days. May we merit to celebrate Pesach in Yerushalayim. And may we continue to build the Mishkan within ourselves and within our communities, one act of love and unity at a time.

In loving memory of my grandmother, Tzila bas Avraham Chaim, zichronah livrachah, a woman who expressed love for all Jews and did what she could to bring them together, especially at our Pesach sedarim growing up. She embodied these values of love, peace, and devotion to Hashem.

Have a wonderful Shabbos.